

International Relations Theory Final Examination

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Department of Political Science and International Relations

Eastern Mediterranean University

ALI GOLDASTEH _____ 22500593

Section 1: Short Answer Questions (4 Points)

1.1 Realism: According to Waltz, what are the two criteria that define the international political structure? How do realists view the possibility of fundamental change in the international system? Explain the different perspectives on the balance of power (unipolarity, bipolarity, multipolarity). (1 point)

Kenneth Waltz argues that there are two criteria for defining the international political structure: a principle of arrangement and the distribution of capabilities. The first one refers to how the states have relationships with each other. In contrast with the system within states that is not based on hierarchy, the system between states is self-help or hierarchical. He claims that this principle is fixed and there is no chance to change over time. Thereby, it creates a limitation for labor division between states that are same in functions in international structure. What is not fixed is the second

principle: the distribution of capabilities because the abilities of states are different to do their task. The possibilities of fundamental change in the international system, from a realist perspective, are impossible, because the character of the international environment (anarchy) is unchangeable. For classic realists, it is because of the nature of humans and for neorealists it is due to the fixed nature of the system. What can be changed is the distribution of power between the major powers. Critics believe that this deterministic view place cooperation between states under power distribution (Burchill et al., 2005; Griffiths et al., 2008).

The empirical reference for the second principle (variable) is the number of great powers that control the system. It can be unipolar, bipolar, or multipolar. He found eight possibilities. Waltz believes that bipolarities are the best shape of power distribution in order to achieve balance of power. The Cold War period is an example of unipolarity, when the US and Soviet Union, according to the recognition of the capabilities of oneself and the other party (to some extent), created harmony. Identifying the threat in bipolarity is easier in comparison with the other models. In the unipolarity, a great power dictates its interest to the international system. But the other powerful states threat hegemon. Therefore, the stability of the system is at risk. The problem of multipolarity refers to how to manage power distribution. In this situation, major states create alliances due to retain their security. As alliances have instability in their natures, the multipolar system will be unstable (Burchill et al., 2005; Griffiths et al., 2008).

1.2 Liberal Internationalism: What are the core tenets of Liberal Internationalism post-Cold War, as outlined by [Burchill](#)? How does this approach differ from realism in its view of international cooperation? (1 point)

The failure of the Soviet Union was considered as the victory of an ideal state in which a set of principles are the code of success. In this period, there was increasing influence of liberalism in academic arena. Because before that, liberalism was put in the margin of International Relations. But the collapse of soviet gave a chance to liberals for claiming, as Fukuyama said, there is no competing theory left: “it was ‘the end point of mankind’s ideological evolution’ and the ‘final form of human government’.” Indeed, liberal capitalism as superior model of political economy is the best form of life for human beings. It comes from the liberal idea about history that is progressive, linear and directional to the final step of human evolution, which means liberal democracy. Without any obstacle including communism, serious national and cultural distinctions (Burchill et al., 2005).

Fukuyama, in the 1990s, tried to extend long belief among liberalist in which expanding domestic legitimate principles of a democratic society to international order where states have relationship with each other can end the conflicts. The key principles are peace, trade, international institutions, interdependency and human rights. Based on Kant’s perspective, Peace is natural, and war is antinatural and irrational. While realists consider that war is inevitable. They believe that in the anarchical environment, balance of power and relying on yourself to achieve security are main factors. Nevertheless, democratic peace theory shows that democratic states have no tendency to resolve their problem with one another by war. Therefore, they make a zone of peace. Increasing liberal-democrat state across the world can expand the zone of peace. But the problem of conflict between democratic state and non-democratic state has remained. There is a contradictory between the spirit of trade and war. Thus, free trade can make economic self-interest based on theory of comparative advantage in order to restrain conflict. It stays versus the realist idea in which relative gain is possible, and state’s self-interest is the top of issues. However, liberals articulate that

interdependence like cooperation and integration in the European Union demonstrates that the possibility of conflict decreases because of common interest. By contrast, realism states that alliance is not perpetual, it is created for certain reasons and will disappear after the situation changes. Relationships between the US and Soviet Union, before WWII (in hostile manner), during WWII (friendly because of common enemy), after WWII (hostile again); confirm realism view (Burchill et al., 2005).

Liberal Internationalism asserts that international institutions play a crucial role in this vision by encouraging cooperation, monitoring compliance, adjusting rules, and making sanctions. It can happen in an anarchical world. Human rights and relevant institutions are the other principles that encourage states to comply with human freedom. A state that has appropriate with its citizen is less aggressive in its international behavior. Meanwhile, realism mentions that international organizations are the hand tool of major states for improving their interests. Human intervention is the other debate in this field. Realists were against the US decision to interfere in human issues. In sum, an 'inside-out' approach has been pursued by Liberal Internationalism. In the other hand, the events of 9/11 build a big question about these principles in favor of realists (Burchill et al., 2005). They "such as Waltz, believe that liberals are guilty of 'reductionism' when they should be highlighting the 'systemic' features of international relations. This conflict between 'inside-out' and 'outside-in' approaches to international relations has become an important line of demarcation in modern international theory." (Burchill et al., 2005, p. 57)

1.3 Critical Theory: What role does the "politics of knowledge" play in shaping IR according to Linklater? How does critical theory challenge the idea of value-free inquiry in international relations? (1 point)

The traditional theories pursue positivism as an approach in that by using scientific methods and quantitative manners to find out social laws and to predict behavior of humans. The primary accepted principle in positivism is that the world and the system existing on its own are fixed. Therefore, the function of positivism is solving problems in this world. The issue is that positivism creates some knowledge (for solving issues) that led to increase administration efficiency of society. Due to the lack of ethical dimension in Positivism, the reasons why goals should be achieved are not explained but just it can explain how can achieve ends. What Weber called iron cage is rooted in "value-neutral" knowledge led to prioritize efficiency over humanity. When reason becomes instrumental (rationality), the potential of emancipation and creative thought are lost. Indeed, knowledge produced in positivism serves to those who are community administrators with specific political approach. Habermas improved Ashly's idea about explanations of the social world that are not objective but are the result of sectorial political interests and aspirations. He used the term of 'knowledge-constitutive interests.' In effect, knowledge is not neutral but in contrast serves to the motives of its creators. "In Cox's much-quoted phrase, theories are 'always for someone and for some purpose'." It is so far from enlightenment ideals including emancipation and increasing human freedom. Knowledge becomes to instrumental reason to control society and suppression. Horkheimer argued that science could provide means to an end, it could not dictate moral values or purposes; it could explain what is but not what ought to be. Knowledge can reduce to means to perpetuate political and social control and to justify domination. According to Cox's

Perspective, theories support certain interests over others, the idea of value-free inquiry in international relations can be challenged (Griffiths, 2007).

1.4 Constructivism: According to Reus-Smit, how does anarchy differ based on social interactions and shared norms? Provide a quote from the assigned readings to support your answer. What are the implications of this view of anarchy for international relations? (1 point)

The Reus-Smit's question about the reason of why constructivists are called constructivists is proper step to find the attitude of constructivism on anarchy. His response is about the origin of constructivism that comes from sociology. Constructivists insist on "social determinants of social and political agency and action." Thanks to constructivists, the end of Cold War could become explainable. The matter that main mainstream with believe on anarchy could not find an accurate interpretation for it. According to this perspective, Alexander Wendt's words make sense: "Anarchy is what States Make of it"(Burchill et al., 2005; Wendt, 1992a).

In contrast with the definition of realism on anarchy in which states consider each other as threats based on enmity and power politics, constructivism mentions that concepts have been shaped socially by norms and identities not a solid and unchangeable reality. They are not merely rational atomistic beings. Wendt said: "if society "forgets" what a university is, the powers and practices of professor and student cease to exist; if the United States and Soviet Union decide that they are no longer enemies, "the cold war is over. It is collective meanings that constitute the structures which organize our actions." (Wendt, 1992b)

Reus-Smit articulates an example to explain the importance of non-material factors: the difference of US's relationships with Canada and Cuba. They are near to United States as neighbors. The balance of military power cannot explain the difference relations. Canada has good relationship with US, while Cuba is interpreted as an enemy by Americans. As Reus-Smit said: "Ideas about identity, the logics of ideology and established structures of friendship and enmity lend the material balance of power between Canada and the United States and Cuba and the United States radically different meanings." Indeed, "material resources only acquire meaning for human action through the structure of shared knowledge in which they are embedded." (Burchill et al., 2005)

As a result, because anarchy is socially constructed, the behavior of states and the nature of the international system can evolve over time through shifts in norms and identities. It is the context (including norms, culture, identity, etc.) that shows anarchy is what. Nuclear weapon of Britain is not a threat for US, while same thing from North Korea is not acceptable. Accordingly, the implications of this view of anarchy for international relations are the chance to go beyond static definition in order to more understanding international issues in a dynamic manner, considering non-material factors, and most important: a real opportunity to deal with conflict with the help of social tools (Burchill et al., 2005).

Section 2: Analytical Essays (10 Points)

2.1 State and Sovereignty: Drawing on the work of Ashley, explain how the concept of sovereignty is constructed, and how this relates to the idea of anarchy. How do states attempt to "expunge any traces of anarchy that reside within them"? Discuss

challenges to sovereignty by non-Western states and implications for international relations. (5 points)

Before examining the relationship between state and sovereignty from Richard Ashley's point of view, it is necessary to consider some postmodernist concepts and attitudes in order to better understand it. In Postmodern approach, knowledge is neither neutral nor purely cognitive but inseparable from power and politics (Burchill et al., 2005).

Individuals, events, structures as distinctive entities are created by historical, cultural, and social practices and they have no intrinsic essences. Moreover, theorists are part of the world that want to study. Their observation thus become objective not like God from top of the world. Focus on processes and practices give post-structuralist experts a chance to question concepts such as state, identity, and sovereignty (Griffiths, 2007).

Textuality shows how by which power, politics, and societal realities have emerged and are constructed. It challenges the foundations of traditional thought. The process that diverse interpretations and representations reciprocally participate to constitution of the "real world." In this path, deconstruction and double reading are strategies to demonstrate hierarchical oppositions, structural parasitism, and instability (Burchill et al., 2005).

Derrida suggests that double reading helps us have a complete look at phenomena and institutions. The first reading is to understand the dominant interpretation. Existing basic assumptions and conventional arguments are expressed in which the structure and coherence of the phenomenon or institution is discovered. But in order not to succumb to the first reading, which gives us a one-dimensional understanding, we need to read it again. The second reading helps to find the points of instability in the text, discourse, or institutions. In fact, double reading, which is also a form of

deconstruction, allows us to grasp both the factors that make up the discourse or the social institution and to know the internal tensions. This is the method that Ashley used to examine the issue of anarchy, that is, the double reading of anarchy (Burchill et al., 2005).

What is known in international relations as anarchy is a concept used by the mainstream to describe power politics. Ashley questions the inference of power politics from the lack of central sovereignty in international relations. In the first reading, he depicts anarchy in a conventional way. But in the second reading, it deals with the negation relationship created for the concepts of anarchy and sovereignty. This means that anarchy means the absence of sovereignty. In this definition, both concepts are independent of each other and are opposed to each other. If we accept the assumption of this dichotomy, we must find a realm of identity, homogeneity, order, and progress within inside, which is guaranteed by a legitimate force, unlike the world outside of the sovereign state. To show this difference, it is necessary that sovereign states be free from any anarchy, so that the distinction between sovereignty and anarchy can be seen. To show this difference, it is necessary that sovereign states be free from any anarchy, so that the distinction between sovereignty and anarchy can be seen. That is, states must eliminate any anarchy within themselves. As Ashley argued, transversal struggles (Internal dissent) should be repressed because they create a doubt against sovereign identity. He articulated that “to confirm the opposition between sovereignty and anarchy as mutually exclusive and exhaustive” led to “double exclusion.” (Burchill et al., 2005)

One of the ways to eliminate anarchy within the state is to create a domesticated political space that is separated from the outside by a border. The attempt to create a uniform identity, which is prescribed by the Western world as a standard for all governments, can lead to heartbreaking disasters such as genocide by combining with violence of state, whose legitimacy is provided by

the mainstream theories. It will happen much more in non-western countries that are struggling with many problems. Artificial borders made by imperialist countries, severe weakness of economic and political structures, ethnic diversity in a country that has not experienced coexistence or is deliberately deprived of it, and normative pressures arising from Western standards to make all states look like Western countries without considering cultural differences are examples of these problems (Burchill et al., 2005).

Violence is defined as an essential factor to create states and then maintain them not a response to anarchy as the traditional views have narrated. Guantánamo is an example of suspension of law by state in order to using violence. Boundaries as one element of state is a product of political struggles over power. The war in Bosnia shows that the state identity defined by modern nation-state logic led to genocide because the state tends to be a homogeneous political community. In effect, from the Postmodernism perspective, the concept of state is not considered as a pre-existing, natural entity. In contrast, political practices continuously create it called statecraft (Burchill et al., 2005).

Examples of state building by Western countries led by the United States can be seen in Afghanistan and Iraq. The result of the attempt to orderly establish governing institutions in a manner that was not compatible with the ethnic, religious, and cultural diversity of these societies led to the return of the Taliban in Afghanistan and the creation of ISIS and militia groups in Iraq. To carry out the process of state building, attention was paid to the standards derived from western knowledge and norms, which could not be adapted to the local conditions. Noteworthy are the labels applied to everything that is different from the West, such as backward, developing, or underdeveloped states. These sovereign challenges created by the major powers in the world system for other states can disturb the security and economic stability in the world. What Ashley

does is to show the hidden factors in the dominant thinking that ignores the social and indigenous structures of different societies and tries to build its own narrative.

To solve this problem, there is a need to create more diverse and fair governance structures. But this is the end of postmodernism. Because they have no hope for change and do not offer a solution. Richard Ashley's emphasis is on social factors, and, like other postmodernists, he distances himself from confirming a single truth. But aren't material factors important in creating such conditions? Are all the blames on the West and other factors are not involved? Is it not possible to criticize the postmodernists with their own tools, the existence of diverse narratives of phenomena? The narrative of postmodernism can be considered as one of all narratives. By contrast of Critical theory, we couldn't use knowledge to critique and change social systems because Knowledge is shaped by power and is contingent and fragmented. As there is not a unique truth and interpretations from different perspectives can change the meaning of phenomena, Opportunity and threat are simultaneously born by post-structuralism. As long as gives a chance to observe political issues from distinctive dimensions, it creates the possibility of justification. For instance, Al-Qaeda and behavior of its members are rooted in Cold War and fostering them by west especially US to counter against Soviet Union in Afghanistan and implications of US during Gulf war. It can be understandable, and observers are convinced that the issues must be investigated from the origins. But the path of justification of unethical actions is opened because it can shift the blame from the perpetrator to the circumstances. Indeed, by taking the shared meaning from morality, the fog dominates over responsibility, humanity, and sense of empathy due to there is not a truth. Fragmentized world in this perspective gives a chance to authoritarians to justify violations against human rights. Can the world be considered as separate islands where the responsibility of one side to another one will be reduced? (Burchill et al., 2005)

2.6 The English School and Global Order: How does the English School view the relationship between order and justice in international affairs? Discuss the "revolt against the West" and its implications for contemporary IR, including an assessment of whether the English School's methodology is suited to addressing these issues. (5 points)

English School put itself a place between realism that believes international system and idealism which pursues world society (Kantian view). Scholars in English School argue that sovereign states form a society in anarchic world. Hedley Bull expressed the term of 'anarchical society' in that sovereign states shape an anarchic society instead to submit to volition of a higher power. International society stems from Grotian perspective in which members are states not individuals. Accordingly, English School is based on state-centric approach. Despite the absence of hierarchy political authority, the level of order exists between states more than the level of violence. It seems that the components of Realism like security and survival have appeared in English School. Nevertheless, Wight who believe rationalism as origin of English School place it via media between Realism and revolutionism. The latter regards the possibility of peace and justice instead of violence in international order. English School has mentioned a limited progressivist account in international level of politics. Both liberal or utopian tendency to the possibility of a world community and focus of realism on security and power are considerable insights in international system from English School's perspective. The art of accommodation and compromise that has

been developed by states creates the possibility of an international society due to common interest in restriction of use of force (Burchill et al., 2005; Griffiths, 2007).

To understand the relationship between order and justice at an international level, two conceptions should be considered in international society. The solidarity of the states as central Grotian assumption mentions international law to recognize just and unjust war, human rights etc. Pluralism is against this approach. It focuses on state sovereignty and minimal shared norms for coexistence. Bull argues that in the pluralist international society which was shaped after WWII the possibility of more solidarity between states as the basic members of international society has no real chance. The reasons lie in the primary aims of international society. There is a contradiction between preserving the sovereignty of each state and two other goals, preserving the balance of power and maintaining peace. The former is usually a victim versus two others because order takes precedence over justice. NPT is an example of this choice. It can be interpreted that the right of those states which do not have nuclear weapons is limited in favor of maintaining order. In the doctrine of natural law, as Hedley Bull found out, there is a priority in which historically ideas of human justice take precedence over the development of ideas of interstate or international justice. John Vincent mentioned that international society is 'functional' or utilitarian rather than 'cultural' or moral in character (Burchill et al., 2005; Griffiths, 2007).

But the important question is who defines justice, is its meaning the result of the consensus of all members of international society or is it a result of concepts created in Western societies, which so-called spread from within them to the outside. When the international society decides not to intervene in the Rwandan genocide, but NATO takes action against Serbia, or the claim of destroying Saddam Hussein's weapons of mass destruction becomes a pretext for a Western military attack, we are faced with a selective justice that serves to the interests of the West, not the

international society. A very contradictory example with the English School is the case of Syria. The behavior of Western states as claimants of order or justice in the world society did not make any serious effort to prioritize one over the other. No human rights intervention took place in Syria, nor was retaining order by government supported. The result was the growth of extremist groups, the strengthening of proxy groups, the widespread production of narcotics by the Syrian government, and the displacement of millions of Syrian civilians. All these events harmed both order and justice, but the world community was indifferent or less responsive to it. The mentioned example can challenge the nature of the thinking of the English School, because neither pluralism nor solidarity as the branches of this approach have had an objective manifestation in the Syrian affair (Burchill et al., 2005).

Expansion of international society occurred when different civilizations dismantle moral superiority and political invincibility within Europe's sense after a long struggle. There is a difference between the international system and international society. For instance, at the end of eighteenth century, different civilizations were placed in the international system (Burchill et al., 2005).

“What this meant was that different civilizations belonged to an international system in the eighteenth century. With the expansion of Europe, other peoples were forced to comply with its conception of the world and, gradually, most of those societies came to accept European principles of international society. But they came to enjoy equal membership of the international society of states only after a long struggle to dismantle Europe's sense of its own moral superiority and political invincibility” (Burchill et al., 2005)

‘The revolt against the West’ is the term of these struggles that was called by Bull. Five main components of struggle are the struggle for equal sovereignty (by China and Japan), the political

revolt against the West (former colonies), the racial revolt against the West (abolish slavery), the economic revolt against global commercial and financial system created by west, the cultural revolt against Western cultural imperialism (like liberal human rights) (Burchill et al., 2005).

In the first four cases, the main issue was that the colonial powers applied the concepts of freedom and equality only in their own society, and the way they behaved with other societies was not based on their own accepted principles. Western powers discriminated significantly in their behavior with other societies, as if the civilized society was the only Western society and justice should be observed only for them. The purpose of the cultural revolt was, in fact, different and related to the West's attempt to dictate its values to other societies. Examining these events shows that non-western civilizations and societies are trying to have a voice. What is meant by justice and order in the international community is not the representation of all cultures and voices, but the continuation of the one-dimensional approach of the dominant world, whose power to maintain a single voice in the international world is now being questioned. BRICS is an example of the efforts of countries outside the western civilization that want to have the same status as the western powers. But the question here is whether there is basically a global society, or this is only an incomplete interpretation of international relations. The way western societies deal with the killing of Palestinian women and children raises the question that values such as human rights are still used in a discriminatory manner. It seems that what is expressed as a balance between order and justice is a pressure lever in the hands of powerful states and not a tangible reality for weak countries and suffering people. Ignoring or downplaying the role of non-state actors in the English School is another significant problem that does not correspond to the realities of the contemporary world. How can the power of Elon Musk, as an American owner of a multinational company, in influencing European societies be interpreted in the English approach. His support for extreme

right-wing parties in Germany, which brings the possibility of the collapse of the order of the European society, is one of the examples to think about in the problems of our world today. It seems that the English School needs a fundamental revision of its assumptions in order to be useful for the contemporary world and provide practical solutions.

Section 3: Simulation Exercise (4 Points)

3.2 The Russia-Ukraine Conflict: Analyze the ongoing conflict between Russia and Ukraine, including the involvement of NATO and other external actors.

To achieve a realistic solution to the Russia-Ukraine conflict, I will apply the theoretical framework of realism. To find insights into the asymmetric conditions of a great power conflict with a smaller state, I will use the results and approaches of the Winter War between the Soviet Union and Finland from 1939 to 1940. The potential lessons of the Winter War could provide a solution to the current conflict in the peace negotiations between Ukraine and Russia. I will then discuss the limitations of realism, and what practical solutions liberalism, as an alternative theory, might offer.

The balance of power between states is based on hard power. Conflict is inevitable, and power dynamics are effective in creating it. There is no guarantee of maintaining stability and peace by giving privileges and power to one actor. Providing moral solutions is often unsustainable in the realist view (Donnelly, 2000). Realism focuses on a pragmatic approach to conflict resolution and considers taking a strong stance essential for lasting peace. States are the main participants in the international system. The distribution of power in this system affects how states behave (Bell, 2017). Russia's aggression is the result of Russia's desire to defend its sphere of influence. Western

responses to this war reflect their security interests. Sanctions against Russia and support for Ukraine have been designed to isolate Russia (Chauhdry & Ali, 2024).

On November 30, 1939, the Soviets, concerned about the security of Leningrad and fearing that Germany would use Finland as a base, invaded Finland. Finland was almost alone in the face of the massive Soviet invasion. It resisted longer than the Soviets had anticipated. Soviet pressure increased in the spring of 1940. Finland became convinced that it could not expect any real help from other countries. Finland accepted the peace treaty by accepting the loss of ten percent of its territory, as it prioritized the preservation of autonomy (Anderson, 1954; Beck, 1981; Nenyte et al., 2015).

Britain did not support Finland, because it was likely that it would be able to unite against Germany with the Soviet Union. The United States and Sweden pursued a policy of non-intervention. There were disagreements between France and Britain even after the end of the Winter War. The League of Nations as an international organization did not have a positive impact on the fate of Finland and did not help resolve the conflict (Bayer, 1981; Rentola, 2013).

The Russian invasion of Ukraine, under the chosen name of Operation Special Forces, was launched by Putin on February 24, 2022. The reason for the invasion was to quickly seize Ukraine because the West had taken control of Ukraine, which is Russia's sphere of influence. Despite Russia's military superiority, Ukraine has resisted, yet Russia occupies about twenty percent of Ukraine's territory (Allison, 2022; MacMillan, 2023).

According to Chester Crocker's arguments, three scenarios for the future of this conflict can be drawn: continued fighting leading to attrition, a temporary armistice, and peace based on an international agreement. For the continuation of the war, and a temporary armistice, Ukraine needs

the continued support of its supporting countries. This possibility is not guaranteed given the dynamic conditions of the world. The third scenario requires the supervision and cooperation of partner and neighboring countries, and the Security Council. There does not seem to be a promising sign of the effective role of the UN in this conflict. On the other hand, international pressure for peace and negotiations has not yielded results. It seems that the United States also prefers to see a weakening Russia (Crocker, 2022; Sweijs & Bertolini, 2022).

Gerard Toal's argument about the taboo on granting territorial concessions is worth considering. In fact, it seems that Ukraine, and the supporting coalition such as the United States, and NATO countries all share the taboo on granting territorial concessions. John Mearsheimer also blames the United States and its allies, believing that they want to scare Russia into stopping such aggressions. But it seems that with Trump coming to power, Ukraine should prepare for compromise. Mearsheimer believes that ignoring Russian concerns about its sphere of influence and emphasizing Ukraine's membership in NATO is what caused Russia to invade Ukraine (Mearsheimer, 2022; Toal, 2024).

Given this taboo, the West does not see negotiation as an option. What is important for Ukraine is to decide between the sacred value of preserving its territory and integrity and continuing an indefinite and endless war that could lead to the destruction of all of Ukraine. Time is of the essence in determining the outcome of this conflict, and timely decisions are crucial. Reclaiming the lost territory is potentially time-consuming and devastating. It will cost a huge amount of lives (Toal, 2024).

Veronica Anghel criticizes Gerard Tolle's ideas about negotiating over the territories occupied by Russia. She believes that this solution is simplistic and may not lead to a lasting peace. Russia's goal in this invasion is to consolidate its power, not to expand its territory. Anghel's alternative

approach is realistic and pragmatic. She emphasizes security guarantees, rejects territorial concessions, and seeks a long-term, stable solution for Ukraine and Europe. She proposes a coherent and united vision in the West to end the invasion, and deal with Russia. Both insist on the role of NATO as prominent third actors. Margaret MacMillan mentions imposing agreement to the parties involved by China and United States. The other solution will be failure of one of them (Anghel, 2024; MacMillan, 2023).

So far, realistic approaches such as sanctions against Russia and support for Ukraine have not brought the war to a conclusion, but the outcome depends on the intervention of the great powers. If they do not intervene, the territories occupied by Russia will be annexed to the Russian Federation. It should be noted that the different contexts and world order systems in the two wars must be considered in proposing a solution (Allison, 2022). There are criticisms of the realist view of aggression. Aggressive realism emphasizes power dynamics and ignores other normative and rational motives that govern state behavior. Fear, material factors, military power, and inequality are not the only factors justifying state behavior, and it ignores moral, emotional, and psychological dimensions (Chauhdry & Ali, 2024).

By drawing on the theory of liberal internationalism, and its emphasis on the importance of international norms and institutions in maintaining peace and stability, a solution can be offered to the Russia-Ukraine conflict. The international community must defend the rights of Ukraine and its people, and democratic values, and protect human rights. By adopting a coordinated and integrated approach towards Russia, they can help resolve the crisis. Participation in collective problem-solving, and the exercise of shared governance, are important for addressing global challenges in finding solutions to this conflict. The flaw in this approach is that it ignores Russia's

security concerns. Over-reliance on international institutions has also not yielded desirable and effective results in practice (Chauhdry & Ali, 2024).

Realism offers a fuller understanding of the concerns of both countries. On the other hand, according to the principles of liberalism, Russia's aggression is a violation of international law, and the international community must defend Ukraine's security and collective security. Both perspectives offer insights. Margaret MacMillan points to the end of World War I, the shift in the balance of power, the weakening of Britain, and the rise of the United States in her argument. She argues that the war in Ukraine could end with the weakening of Russia and the rise of a powerful China. Naturally, losers do not accept defeat easily, and winners can pursue a magnanimous policy (MacMillan, 2023).

Ukraine using the historical lessons of the Winter War and taking a similar action could be a realistic solution. It would give Ukraine and its people the opportunity to maintain autonomy. And of course, according to some scholars, it could create potential future threats to Russia. Otherwise, the outcome would depend on many complex factors. Military dynamics on the battlefield, and Western military support, and domestic pressures from the people in Ukraine and Russia, could all be effective in determining the outcome.

Section 4: Synthesis and Reflection:

4.1 Reflect on the challenges and opportunities for building a more inclusive and just international order. Consider diverse worldviews, material and ideational factors, and the role of different actors (states, non-state actors, individuals).

Specifically, discuss which theoretical perspective you have found most useful for thinking about these issues, and why.

Response to this question is not easy due to the complexity of international issues and sophisticated interconnections between distinct actors. The other dimension that can hard the condition is related to the theories. Each theory contains some capabilities to explain or interpret our world, meanwhile approaches have weaknesses. Debilities can be divided into three clusters. First, theories couldn't response to all demands, because of limitations of their structures. For instance, realism failed to explain the collapse of the Soviet Union owing to what occurred is out of its point of view and principles. Second, some theories are so far from realities or so idealist. They lack solutions or proposals for ameliorate international politics such as postmodernism. Third, some methods that theories pursue do not consider human concepts like ethics, justice, human rights. Offensive realism is one of the famous views in this field. Nevertheless, we require to contemplate frameworks in order to acquire road maps.

As I have traced the history of Europe, what is exclamatory is changing relationship between France and Germany after some mass destructive war. Who could imagine the current positive interconnection between them a hundred years ago? The European Union inspires me to think about the possibility of changes. According to my perspective, liberalism and constructivism, despite their shortcomings, are my choice. Cooperation in EU with numerous states, cultures, ethnics, languages has been achieved by members. Creation of common ground, norms, identity (as EU members), and welfare are achievements of Europeans. It was not easy or without challenges. Brexit is an example that shows that building takes care, and sometimes uncalculated factors play the role of obstacles.

To judge fairly, it should consider the context. Different environments demand certain essentials. With blind eyes the result will be catastrophic. For example, Africa is another context. Therefore, to adopt a success method for a region, it requires to count domestic factors including indigenous knowledge, norms, culture, the level of economic and political development, etc. Accordingly, we need dynamic approaches instead of static theories that tend to be practical. The changes of constructivism as new constructivism that includes practice theory to deal with critiques is one of my examples. I am in the first step of International Relations. Hence, I must strive more to attain better comprehensive analysis.

4.2 Reflect on how your understanding of international relations theory has evolved over the course of this class and identify at least one area in which you would like to do further research.

I learned two very important things in this course. First, I must have a critical analytical approach to the theories of international relations in order to be aware of all the positive and negative aspects of each point of view. To do this method, I need to engage with the topics in a deeper way. In addition, I realized that theories should be used to understand the current world issues that all actors such as states, NGOs, international organizations, and individuals are facing.

What I am interested in pursuing is a deeper understanding of the existing tensions in our world between the great powers. One of the important points in these tensions is the interest of politicians, media, and journals to inflame disputes. New constructivism, which tries to overcome the shortcomings of traditional constructivism, is a suitable field to pursue my desire. Practice theory attempts to add more practical solutions to constructivism.

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